

Understanding Farm Succession by the Objective Hermeneutics Method

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Abstract

While farm succession has been well explored using quantitative data, we use the qualitative, case-oriented method of objective hermeneutics to explore important issues in succession processes. Objective hermeneutics makes use of short text sequences from interviews, exploiting the relationship between societal norms and the constitutive rules resulting from personal biographies. A case study including an intra-family succession, an almost-failed succession and an inter-family succession is analysed with reference to three sequences from an interview. It is shown that hierarchy plays a big role in succession processes within the family. Another result is the emotional turmoil that can result from a failed succession.

Introduction

The importance of the process of farm succession in family farming systems can hardly be overestimated. As Mann and Mante (2004) show, agricultural structures in terms of average farm size and the share of part-time farming are strongly derived from individual farm succession decisions. It is therefore worthwhile to explore in detail the driving factors in succession and the abandonment (failed succession) of farming.

Having said this, an impressive body of literature with quantitative data about farm succession exists (Fennel 1981; Keating and Little 1997; Errington 1998, 1999; Baker *et al.* 2001; Martz and Brueckner 2003). A farm succession research network has been established by the universities of Plymouth and of Iowa and surveys have been carried out within and outside this network. We therefore know a lot about the average ages at the time of farm succession in different countries, together with the influence of farm size and character on the likeliness of being taken over and about the influence of education, to name just a few of the aspects that can easily be gathered by questionnaires.

Both the difficulty of interpreting data from quantitative studies (Viladomin *et al.* 1996) and first qualitative attempts (Rossier and Wyss 2006) have indicated, however, that farm succession is much more than just a technical process. Elderly farmers

usually reject the idea of giving up their farm even if they do not have a successor, and willingness to succeed is often seen as a matter of honour rather than as a question of utility maximisation (Crockett 2004). Kennedy (1991) sees farm inheritance as part of a long-term exchange relationship. Weiss (1999) and Corsi (2004) emphasise the importance of entrepreneurial abilities and farm-specific knowledge, whereas Dumas *et al.* (1995) focus instead on the cultural side. It is impossible to understand the underlying psychological and sociological forces determining farm succession by surveys alone. Qualitative research provides a necessary supplement.

In the English-speaking world, grounded theory is probably seen as the most likely methodological option for exploring, in a qualitative manner, the subjective factors that influence the process of farm succession. Despite the general dominance of quantitative approaches (Debertin and Pagoulatos 1992; Bitsch 2005), grounded theory is well established among social scientists and has already been applied to similar questions (Bryant 1999). However, in German-speaking countries the first choice is more often the analysis of interview records by the method of objective hermeneutics. This method has been developed with the strong claim that it 'provides the basic operation of measuring and generating data relevant for theory in social sciences' (Oevermann *et al.* 1979, p. 352). In Germany, Austria and Switzerland it is supported by a large and thriving society with annual meetings and documented by a large number of books and articles. In these times of (not only) scientific globalisation, it is a noteworthy peculiarity that the method has attracted massive attention in only a small part of the world and almost none in the rest.

This peculiarity has been described (Flick 2002), but not challenged as yet. In order to initiate an international discussion about the potentials of the method, Section 2 outlines the philosophy and content of objective hermeneutics. Section 3 presents a case study giving some insights into the process of farm succession and Section 4 concludes.

The method of objective hermeneutics

To start with the obvious: while quantitative research tries to detect significant causal relations and measurable frequencies, qualitative studies are intended both to develop theories and to discover the unexpected. In this respect, objective hermeneutics is the most qualitative approach that can be imagined, that is, it lies farthest of all approaches from quantitative methods. Its objective is not to make any standardised statement. According to its founder, Ulrich Oevermann (2004), standardisations miss the object of research to the degree to which the object is not itself standardised. Instead, an attempt is made to explore the lowest level of social substance. This exploration is not claimed to be representative, but the authenticity of the case to be analysed is important.

Social scientists concerned with objective hermeneutics repeatedly emphasise that, unlike in natural sciences, a description of what is happening is not a meaningful tool. They focus on reconstructing realities. The main instrument for collecting social realities is records of interviews, but artwork or pictures have also been used for the purpose of reconstruction. The records used for analysis can come from narrative or semi-structured interviews, but certainly not from standardised questionnaires.

Every sequence which is taken from the record is reflected by the means of broad societal norms. Oevermann (2000) uses the example of greeting as an illustration. When my colleague says 'Hello' to me, there are basically only two ways to react (called a sequential link by Oevermann). I can either greet my colleague back or I can refuse to greet her. Any other possibility, such as pretending not to hear the colleague's 'Hello' merely delays the necessity of deciding between the two options.

Therefore, the main work of analysing sequences of records consists of a detailed analysis of what has been said. What would we have expected to be said in the particular situation? In which other contexts could what was actually said have been said? What follows from the (verbal) choice the person made? In order not to measure what was said against the subjective background of only one single researcher, it is preferable for a group of scientists rather than one individual to concern themselves with the analysis of the sequence (Garz and Kraimer 1994).

In practice, the microscopic process of evaluating a text is rather similar to what is done at the first stage in grounded theory evaluations, namely 'careful, often minute examination and interpretation of data' (Strauss 2004, p. 169). The principal differences between the two schools arise in terms of the steps that follow. Oevermann (2001, p. 66) criticises grounded theory for not being

free of the logic of subsumption, because it is not free from the illusion of approaching the implicit theories of everyday reality by coding the material. If you want to be very close to the 'ground', you use the tool of 'in vivo' coding. This is, however, nothing but double paraphrasing and shows how crudely coding, in general, fumbles on the surface of expressions.

Although this critique has partly been rejected by Oevermann's colleague Hildenbrand (2004), it shows the reluctance of objective hermeneutics to make any generalisations beyond a single case. It is argued in particular that every new phenomenon is often obscured if subsumed by other, well-known observations. The scholars of objective hermeneutics, although often focusing on one particular case, are open to including several different cases. They are reluctant, however, to intermingle different cases, as in grounded theory.

A more accepted supplement for analysis in objective hermeneutics is a historic analysis of the family of those interviewed (Hildenbrand 2005). This analysis may be a very detailed chart depicting two or three generations before the interviewees (in this case, it will usually become necessary to collect the appropriate data from the interviewees after the interview) or it may be rough biographical information. The depth depends on the need for biographical information in order to understand the specifics of the case analysed. This focus on the interviewee's family structure shows rather well where the specific qualities of objective hermeneutics lie: there is a serious attempt to understand the structure of the specific case which is analysed. Every case can be understood in the dialectics between societal conventions and constitutive rules.

Therefore, the specific properties of the method of objective hermeneutics are:

- Reconstruction is preferred to classification, because every standardisation is a subsumption under already known categories.
- Every case can be generalised on the one hand, but makes the specifics of the case clear on the other.

- The method of interpreting the data follows defined rules and is therefore inter-subjectively valid.

Do single cases matter for social scientists trying to understand broad phenomena like farm succession? In this respect, objective hermeneutics is more radical than most other qualitative methods. Although schools like the grounded-theory school claim not to aspire to representativeness, they usually look for a fairly broad sample of people to answer research questions. Objective hermeneutics claims that a single case contains sufficiently interesting material to warrant separate analysis. Any single case should provide insights into both general patterns and specific circumstances. Only an example can show whether this is the case or not. Moreover, although we conducted a series of interviews throughout the whole of Switzerland for our study, collecting and evaluating material from several retired farmers and farming couples, only one case will be presented in any depth in order to explore the insights that the school of objective hermeneutics can provide.

The Ammann family

The case presented here is an elderly farming couple (called *husband* and *wife* below) who ceased farming ten years ago. The interview was carried out in March 2006 and it was transcribed in April. An afternoon in which a group of five people tried to analyse the three sequences shown below was carried out in July 2006, followed by public presentations in which some further aspects of the sequences were revealed.

As the focus is on farm succession, the structures in the family are of moderate importance, so that it will be sufficient to list the biographical information collected in the semi-structured interview. The husband's father originates from a hilly region in eastern Switzerland. He moves to a nearby district where he first becomes a milker. In 1944, he rents (and later buys) a farm 20 miles away.

The husband himself, however, is born in 1929, at a time when his father is still employed as a milker. He is the second of three brothers, the eldest of whom is expected to take over the new family farm. This brother, however, dies in a bike accident in 1950. While the husband had planned to enter a banking career, he now switches his plans and becomes a farmer. In 1956 he marries a woman three years younger than himself and they have three daughters between 1958 and 1966. Throughout this time, he works on his father's farm, which he eventually takes over in 1969. As none of his daughters are interested in taking over the farm, in 1995 he rents all the land, stables and animals to a neighbour at the age of 66. The interview takes place in 2006.

From this brief biographical sketch, it becomes possible to develop various hypotheses about the case with respect to farm succession. The transition made by the husband's father from being a farm worker to becoming the head of his own family farm is certainly an advancement. It could be expected that the family farm is such an achievement that conserving this farm through succession is the most important objective for the husband. Alternatively, it could also be that being a farmer is just one stage among several in the family's advancement. In this case, abandoning the farm would not be seen as a problem if the children were to follow high-profile careers.

Selected sequences from the record now serve to test the hypotheses. While the interview was carried out in the general context of establishing the situation of retired farming couples, it is most effective for our purpose to analyse the sequences in which succession processes are talked about. In addition, it has proved fruitful to analyse the first sequence of the record, where the social structure of the interviewed persons can often be clearly seen (Bude 1998).

3.1 The opening sequence

When the interviewer and her assistant arrived at the Ammann family house, it was the wife who opened the door, led the interviewers into the living room and agreed that the microphone could be set up. As it was clear that the interview was to take place with both husband and wife, the opening sequence of the interview began when the husband entered the room.

Interviewer: Hello, Mr Ammann.

Wife: This is my husband

Interviewer: Lauber. This is Mr Mack, a colleague.

Husband: |Right

Interviewer: and Helmut Zimmermann sends his kind regards.

Husband: Oh. Thank you very much

Interviewer: And thank you very much for allowing us to come

Husband: Yes.

Interviewer: We've already ... said a little bit to your wife, exactly what it's all about

Husband: Yes.

Wife: It's more or less the same as last time, they record it too and afterwards you can pick out the best bits and cut it down or whatever.

Interviewer: Yes, of course, and create a portrait for the agricultural report

Husband: Oh well, yes

Interviewer: Briefly, so that we can show different situations which former farmers and their wives are in, how they are living now and what their life's like ... and how they feel.

Husband: |Yes, I see. If possible, well and good [laughter].

| - simultaneous talk

This opening sequence comes amusingly close to Oevermann's example of the choice of returning a greeting. After the interviewer offers her compliments, the husband who had just entered the room at first chooses not to answer. Instead, the wife fills in by introducing her husband. This is unnecessary from a technical point of view, as there is nobody else in the house and the interviewer has apparently already identified the person who entered. However, this reference is supposed to draw attention away from herself, so far the only person to be spoken to, and direct it towards her husband. The primary purpose of the introduction (perhaps partially prescribed by societal norms) is to unload responsibility from the wife's shoulders.

As the husband does not become active, the interviewer steps in by first introducing herself, then her male assistant. While the wife's reference to her husband may be a first indicator of male dominance in this social environment, this is now the second such indicator. Only when the second male person in the room is introduced does the husband confirm his recognition. For the female interviewer, that did not seem to be necessary.

Due to the husband's passivity the interviewer feels obliged to continue her introductory remarks by passing on compliments from a common acquaintance. Again, the husband does not act like a typical interviewee. He acknowledges and thanks her for the compliments but shows no intention of returning them. The interviewer adapts to this role model and adds an expression of gratefulness for being allowed to do the interview, which is, again, merely acknowledged by the husband. The participants almost seem to be switching from an interview situation to that of a visit, where who asks and who answers is not pre-defined.

The interviewer now tries to find her way back from the opening ceremony to the purpose of the interview. She refers back to her one-to-one talk with the wife about the purpose of the interview. While the husband only confirms this reference, the wife is ready to assist the interviewer. As the interviewer reveals that the wife already has the necessary information, she jumps in to provide her husband with information about the scope of the interview. This includes an affirmative reference to a former interview in which the husband had apparently participated. The continued passivity of the husband makes the wife feel the need to encourage her husband. She promises that only the best of what he says will be quoted, while everything unnecessary will be skipped.

The interviewer and the wife seem almost to compete in providing supportive information to the husband. However, the interviewer introduces a new dimension after having confirmed the wife's remarks. The 'Agricultural Report' is the federal government's annual agricultural policy publication and the interviewer emphasises that the purpose of the interview is to contribute to this official report. By doing so, the interviewer revalues the current interview upwards, as it has become clear that other interviews have already taken place. She succeeds in doing so, as the husband, for the first time, shows signs of appreciation.

This, in turn, seems to encourage the interviewer, who starts to justify the purpose of her study. As she eventually moves on from the objective part of the farmers' situation to the aspect of wellbeing, this seems to convince the husband to abandon his entirely passive position. With his remark, 'If possible, well and good' he shows the first signs of actively steering the conversation. His remark, albeit not very meaningful, is meant to show some signs of optimism. This signal is taken with relief by everyone else in the room, materialising in laughter.

The opening sequence shows the clear dominance of the husband in the relationship. He is clearly understood in the traditionalist sense as the head of the family. This dominant position is even transfused to bystanders like the interviewer, particularly as she is a woman. The respect that the husband shows for the use of his interview in the Agricultural Report shows a firm belief in the hierarchical structure of the state.

Starting out as a farmer

It is important to understand the conditions under which the couple took over the farm, both as a comparison for the same process taking place a generation later and to understand the importance of the process itself. The couple describe how they lived together in the house with his parents.

Wife: I have to say I had a good mother-in-law, almost too good [laughs]

Husband: Yes, they got on almost better than I did with my father, it wasn't that we had big disagreements, but sometimes the young fellow has different ideas from the father or, and, but we got on well together, sure.

Interviewer: That's perfectly normal

Husband: What?

Interviewer: It's quite normal for people not always to have exactly the same ideas.

Wife: Of course you can't, they're different generations, and things change in between.

Husband: |Yes |That's right

Husband: Sure. (---)

Wife: So when did you take over the farm?

Husband: What?

Wife: So when did you take over the farm then?

Husband: A bit late, my father was already 54 or 55 when he bought this property, and I couldn't just say to him after 5 or 10 years, you have to give it to me now, and so I suppose in a way I was just a menial on his farm.

Wife: Yes, so you were, but it was the menial who gave the orders [laughter].

Husband: I could more or less do what I wanted, sure.

Wife: Mostly let him get on with it.

Husband: Oh, we had no problems, certainly not. (-)

Interviewer: So were you employed by your father?

Husband: Yes, we were both the boss in a way [laughter], him more in the cowshed than outside in the fields or the orchard.

Interviewer: Did you take it over directly, or did you lease it to begin with?

Husband: No, straight away, that's right, of course I was easily able to take it over, without many debts, I even had a bit of money of my own, so there were no problems there.

| simultaneous talk; (-) silence (1 second)

It is striking that the wife starts her sentence about the mother-in-law with an obligation: she 'has to' say. Would she rather accuse her mother-in-law of something but feels that she is not allowed to? The only accusation that she dares to speak out is that she was 'too good', although it is left open where the excess goodness of the mother-in-law shows.

The good relationship between the women in the house is used by the husband to contrast this relationship with his own, seemingly problematic relationship with his father. Apparently, on the farm it is the intra-gender relations that matter rather than the inter-gender relations. However, the husband is not willing to speak personally about this, but prefers to say in very general terms that ideas may well differ between son and father. After this general introduction one could expect a closer description of the nature of the problem to follow. Interestingly, this description is introduced with an 'and', but then the husband seems to interrupt himself, changing from 'and' to 'but' and to the assertion that they got along well.

What follows is support from two sides. The interviewer integrates the husband's experience into the normality of conflict. Then, the wife assists the interviewer, affirming the impossibility of complete harmony between the generations. Obviously, this support from his wife's side strengthens the husband. In this sequence he agrees three times with what his wife says. After circumnavigating the fields of conflict with his father in this elegant manner, he seems exhausted and apparently has nothing more to say.

While the interviewer still waits for more information to come, the wife jumps once more into the interviewer's role. Again, this role change seems to provide support for her husband in order to leave the critical subject of inner-family conflict. As she knows that the issue of farm succession is somewhat important for the visitors, she chooses to enter this area now. She does so by asking a question to which everybody knows that she surely knows the answer. While this contradicts the usual expectation of societal conversation, she is willing to appear a bit foolish and even to repeat the question after the husband apparently fails to follow the quick jump from the subject of inner-family conflict.

However, the husband gratefully accepts the rescue and starts to tell the story of the succession. His description of the succession being 'a bit late' leaves open the scale by which this succession was late. Would he have liked an earlier succession? Or was the timing just later than in his neighbours' case? His subsequent words seem to indicate the former. The statement that he 'could not' demand the farm implies that he would have liked to do so. When stating that he was the 'menial', he uses the German word '*halt*' which implies something between fatalism and self-pity. He, who wanted to be a farmer, was for too long a servant.

Now it is, again, the wife who comes to her husband's assistance. To see her husband as a servant seems to be too embarrassing for her. Therefore, she emphasises his dominant position in spite of his formal inferiority. Why would she do so in a very impersonal, generalised way? This way of description might appear more objective and less prone to critique than speaking in a personal manner. However, the notion of the 'servant who gave orders' shows a very interesting tension between formal hierarchies and factual dominance.

Now the issue of dominance during the time of working under his parents is discussed between the couple. The husband seems to agree with what his wife has said ('sure'). However, instead of admitting the dominant position which the wife has claimed for him, he describes his own freedom. This freedom, however, seems to be a freedom within limits. As he was only 'mostly' able to do what he wanted, he still insists that his position was one of inferiority. The argument is not over yet. Again, his wife rejects the claim of inferiority. She insists on the opposite picture, saying that the husband usually gave orders.

The way the husband reacts gives a very typical picture of the couple's role model. By getting somehow the 'last word', he achieves formal dominance. However, as regards content, the wife is, for the time being, no longer contradicted in her claim that the husband had a dominant position. Instead, the husband jumps back to the question of conflict. Now, far too late to be credible, he insists that there were no problems. His own emphasis on what he has said ('surely not') does not make things any better. Rather, it shows that conflicts seemed to be a fairly big issue at that time and they inevitably come back to mind when he thinks back to this time.

After a pause, the interviewer tries to enter the new subject of the formal employment relationship between the husband and his father. Again, the husband is not yet ready to follow the interviewer, giving no concrete answer to the question asked. Instead, he comes back to the issue of dominance between father and son. By giving details about who was in charge of what, it appears important to him to redraw the

picture of his dominance provided by his wife. His wording, in choosing first the areas where 'more he' was in the driver's seat, still shows that it is important to him to show his father's position as a dominant one.

The interviewer does not insist on her question being answered but, instead, asks a second, rather technical question about the process of succession. Once again, it is important for the husband not only to answer technically, but to assure the interviewer that there were no problems.

The text shows that two related subjects play a large role in succession processes as they were repeatedly mentioned by the couple although never raised by the interviewer. One is the issue of conflict and the other is the issue of hierarchy. Farm succession describes the process of transmitting power from one generation to the next. This happens in a social world with very close ties due to the unity of household and enterprise. It is readily understandable that the process of shifting responsibilities entails many new questions every week of working together on the farm. When will the son negotiate with the commercial dairy for the first time? When will be the last time that the father carries out irrigation himself? If the process of farm succession is organised too gradually, the period of potential conflict and power struggle is unnecessarily long. If it is too short, however, the successor will not be adequately prepared. Therefore, farm succession is a walking a tightrope which demands understanding and empathy between generations.

3.3 Giving up farming

As the couple had three daughters, all of whom married into a non-agricultural environment and had no interest in farming, it was clear for the couple they had no intra-family successor for their farm.

Interviewer: How are things now, how's the hand-over process

Husband: [Yes, the take-over process was quite simple, hmm, to begin with we thought we would lease the whole property, with the house and everything, and we looked around a bit for a house, and that was 10 or 12 years ago now, and at that time houses were still quite dear, and I thought, well no, pay that much for a house, no.

Wife: Yes, and, we would have done it, if we hadn't found a suitable tenant.

Husband: That's right, I was just about to say that, he suddenly turned up, a young farmer came to see me, he had a smallholding down there, Häberli his name is, he was still there with his father, and his father would have been

Wife: Over 50

Husband: About 55 or 56, and they didn't have enough to farm together, and then he just asked me if he couldn't take the whole property on lease, when I gave up farming.

Wife: So my husband came home really excited

Husband: [I was a bit scared at the time.

Wife: Yes, but I still remember how you came in the kitchen door for your lunch and said, do you know what, René turned up, and you told me about it, and he was so happy, he was, and then he said right away, we could stay on the in the house.

Interviewer: Oh, yes, because they said they would take over the property.

Wife: Yes.

Husband: All he wanted was the barn and the land.

Wife: Yes, and the livestock.

Husband: Eh?

Wife: He took the livestock as well

Husband: Yes, yes, that's right. That suited me fine at the time, auctioning it off would have been a bit difficult for me, yes sure, no, as

Interviewer: It's still sad to see

Husband: Sure, afterwards it was easy, we got a valuer in, he valued the whole lot, and we looked at it together, and we agreed right away, except for two cows, and they were two exceptional cows, elite cows, and pretty as well, brown with horns, and he said straight away, yes, yes, I'll pay more, and we reached an agreement (-) and the lease is working very well.

Although, this time, the interviewer has to introduce the subject, the husband is very quick to understand the nature of the new subject of farm succession. This is noteworthy as sometimes before, the question had to be repeated before the husband understood it. Now, the husband explains without hesitation that the farm succession process went very simply. Only his pause after this opening remark causes doubt about the degree of simplicity. Then, supported by his wife, he starts the narrative about their first searching for a solution to their situation and then the offer from a neighbour.

The option of moving to a different place is first of all rejected for financial reasons by the husband with a double 'no'. At this point, a conflict between the couple seems to appear. After the husband's decision not to buy a house, the wife pretends to agree ('Yes'), but then she claims that they would still have bought a house if necessary. Apparently, the husband would have preferred to stay on in the house and to lease his land parcel by parcel, while the wife saw the unity of the farm as a priority and wanted the buildings and land to be leased as a whole. Both of them seem eager to leave the subject of this former conflict, which probably never erupted, and to switch to the solution of the succession process.

At this point in the interview, the narrative switches from the past to the present. This indicates that the very moment when the solution to the potential conflict became clear is indeed still very immediate in the husband's mind. While the switch of times indicates this for the husband, the wife later makes the importance of the moment explicit by introducing the sentence with 'I still remember'. Although it is clear that the couple remember everything they recount, it is at this point that remembering has to be emphasised.

After the husband has gone back to the past in the narrative about the farm successor from outside the family, his wife, for the first time in the interview, starts to speak about emotions. She chooses to start with her husband's emotions, saying that he was excited. The husband seems to find it inappropriate to be described by his wife as excited. He interrupts her, saying that he was 'a bit scared at the time'. The wife feels now challenged to re-describe her husband's emotional state, offering now 'so happy' as a third option. After a whole interview in which emotions were never touched upon, we now have to deal with three very different emotional attributes, tending much more to the positive than to the negative side. That shows that the solution offered by the neighbour provided a way out of a looming critical situation.

This is confirmed by the husband himself. While the interviewer turns to the rather technical issue of the farm's livestock, the husband remains on the emotional side of the succession process. Now he admits that the option of portioning the

farms, which he preferred in the first place, would have been emotionally stressful for him. This is verbalised by the interviewer and confirmed once again by the husband.

In the husband's story, he seems unwilling to give up farming altogether. It is hardly surprising that he chooses two cows rather than anything else, as cows are traditionally an object of high prestige in Swiss agriculture. By terming the animals 'elite', this status-seeking function is emphasised by the husband himself.

After the narrative about the process of negotiating the conditions of succession, the husband switches to an evaluation of the present. It is striking that, when describing his relationship with his parents, he denied that there were any problems, whereas now he emphasises that things are 'going fine'.

Why would the couple (or at least the husband) be so happy about the succession solution? Why is it, apparently, so important to avoid splitting up the farm land and buildings? The most probable answer is what Sonkkila (2002) and Mann (2004) term the 'intrinsic value of a farm'. While this may be valid for other sectors to a lesser degree, the existence of a farm seems to be a very important issue for a lot of people, not just farmers. For every 'saved' farm, the individual utility is increased. This phenomenon is particularly strong in countries like Switzerland where farmers play an important role in the national history and culture.

Conclusions

Most sociological research is based on questionnaires. This means that most information available comes from ticks made by a large number of people on a piece of paper. Qualitative research pays the price of abandoning the claim of representativeness in order to use data sources closer to real life. Objective hermeneutics goes one step further by often focusing on a single case study. This allows for fairly in-depth analysis. Analysing the stories of individual people is usually seen as the domain of psychology, and psychologists also use the same methodology. But while sociology is seen as a science of groups, case studies often reveal patterns that are most relevant to groups and group processes.

Given the case study analysed above, the additional information about the challenges of farm succession was considerable. This is admittedly so because the couple interviewed were able to give us information about an intra-family succession and an almost-failed succession which then became an inter-family succession. It became clear that conflict and hierarchy are core issues in intra-family succession. Failed succession and splitting up the farm can cause major emotional turmoil. In the case analysed, intra-family succession apparently provided an optimal solution to the crisis caused by the insecure future of the farm.

Had the interview, together with some other interviews, been coded within a grounded theory framework, some substance of the case and therefore some important insights could well have been lost. The advantages of analysing a particular case in depth, however, do not discredit the achievements of grounded theory, like its potential for constructing typical configurations.

The analysis of selected cases, if carried out in sufficient detail, always leads to an interesting position between the influences of societal norms on the one hand and the

influences of biographical structures on the other. It is the merit of the methodology that it fully exploits the potential of analysing single cases.

It is indeed possible that the potential of objective hermeneutics is overestimated in German-speaking countries. In the rest of the world, however, the potential of this method has still to be explored.

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Appendix: The dialogues in the original language

I.

Interviewerin: Grüezi, Herr Ammann.

Frau: Das ist mein Mann

Interviewerin: Lauber. Das ist der Herr Mack, ein Kollege,

Mann: !Jawoll

Interviewerin: und einen lieben Gruss vom Helmut Zimmermann.

Mann: So. Danke bestens

Interviewerin: Und noch mal auch Ihnen vielen Dank, dass wir kommen durften

Mann: Ja.

Interviewerin: Wir haben jetzt schon ein bisschen mit ihrer Frau ... gesagt, eben, um was es geht

Mann: Ja.

Frau: Es geht ungefähr gleich wie das letzte Mal, er hat es auch aufgenommen und dann nachher kann man das Beste herauslesen und kürzen oder so

Interviewerin: Ja, das auf jeden Fall, und das Portrait machen für den Agrarbericht

Mann: Oh ha, ja

Interviewerin: Einfach, für ein paar, dass wir zeigen können, verschiedene Situationen von ehemaligen Bauern und Bäuerinnen, wie sie heute leben und wohnen und ... und wie das Befinden ist.

Mann: [So, so. Wenn es geht immer gut [lachen].

2.

Frau: Ich muss sagen, dass ich eine gute Schwiegermutter hatte, fast eine zu gute [lacht].

Mann: Ja, es ging fast besser als bei mir und dem Vater, wir hatten nicht gross Differenzen, aber der Junge hat einmal eine andere Idee als der Vater, oder, und, aber wir kamen gut zurecht, sicher.

Interviewerin: Das ist ja auch normal

Mann: Wie?

Interviewerin: Das ist ja normal, dass man nicht immer ganz die gleichen Ideen hat.

Frau: Das kann man ja gar nicht, das sind Generationen, und das wechselt doch zwischen-durch.

Mann: |Ja |Genau

Mann: Sicher. (---)

Frau: Und wann übernahmst du das Gewerbe?

Mann: Hä?

Frau: Und wann übernahmst du dann das Gewerbe?

Mann: Ein wenig spät, der Vater war bereits 54 oder 55 als er diese Liegenschaft kaufte, und da konnte ich doch nicht nach 5, 10 Jahren sagen, so jetzt musst du ihn mir geben, und so war ich halt ein wenig Knecht bei ihm.

Frau: Ja, ja, aber es war der Knecht, der befahl [lachen].

Mann: Ich konnte machen ziemlich, was ich wollte, sicher.

Frau: Meistens machen lassen.

Mann: Moll, es gab keine Probleme, sicher nicht. (-)

Interviewerin: Dann waren sie angestellt beim Vater?

Mann: Ja, wir waren beide ein wenig Chef [lachen], im Kuhstall mehr er als draussen im Acker und im Obstbau.

Interviewerin: Übernahmen sie ihn direkt oder pachteten sie ihn zuerst?

Mann: Nein, gerade direkt, richtig, ich konnte ihn natürlich gut übernehmen, ohne viele Schulden, hatte selber ein wenig eigenes Geld, es gab dort also keine Probleme.

3.

Interviewerin: Wie ist jetzt das, wie ist da der Übergabeprozess

Mann: |Ja, der Übernahmeprozess ging ganz einfach, hm, anfänglich dachten wir, wir würden die ganze Liegenschaft verpachten, mit Haus und allem, und haben uns ein wenig umgeschaut wegen einem Haus, und das ist jetzt etwa 10, 12 Jahre, und da waren die Häuser noch recht teuer, und ich dachte, ja nein, soviel zahlen für ein Haus, nein.

Frau: Ja, und, wir hätten es gemacht, wenn wir nicht einen geeigneten Pächter gefunden hätten.

Mann: Das stimmt, das wollte ich gerade sagen, da kommt plötzlich da unten, ein junger Bauer zu mir, er hat eine Siedlung da unten, Häberli heisst er, da waren noch der Vater und er, und der Vater war da etwa

Frau: Gut 50 gewesen

Mann: Etwa 55, 56 Jahre alt gewesen, und sie hatten zu wenig um gemeinsam zu bauern, und dann hat er mich einmal gefragt, ob er nicht die ganze Liegenschaft in Pacht nehmen könnte, wenn ich aufhöre.

Frau: Da war mein Mann ganz aufgeregt heimgekommen

Mann: !Da bin ich ein wenig erschrocken im Moment.

Frau: Ja, aber ich weiss noch als du zur Küchentür hereinkamst zum Mittagessen und sagtest, weißt du, jetzt kam René und hat mir das erzählt, und er war so glücklich, ja eben, und dann hat er sofort gesagt, wir könnten im Haus bleiben.

Interviewerin: Aha, eben, weil sie sagten die Liegenschaft übernehmen.

Frau: Ja.

Mann: Er wollte nur die Scheune und das Land.

Frau: Ja, und das Inventar.

Mann: Hä?

Frau: Das Inventar hat er auch

Mann: Ja, ja, eben. Das passte mir in dem Moment gut, so eine Versteigerung machen, hätte mir ein wenig Mühe bereitet, ja sicher, nein, da

Interviewerin: Das macht noch weh, wenn man sieht

Mann: Sicher, nachher ging das einfach, wir hatten einen Schätzer, der hat die ganze Sache geschätzt, und wir schauten es gemeinsam an, und wurden sofort einig, bis auf zwei Kühe, und das sind zwei Ausnahmekühe, Elitekühe, und auch schöne, Braune mit Hörner, und er sagte sofort, ja, ja, ich gebe mehr, und wir wurden einig (--) und das geht bestens mit der Pacht.

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